



Subject Vision and Intent: British Sign Language

Our Vision

At King's Cross Academy, we believe that every child should recognise the importance and value of communication in all its forms. Our unique co-location with Frank Barnes School for Deaf Children provides an extraordinary opportunity for children to experience British Sign Language (BSL) as a living language and a natural part of the community in which they learn.

Our ambition is for children to develop the confidence to communicate using BSL while developing their knowledge and understanding of Deaf culture and identity. We want children to recognise that communication extends beyond spoken language and to appreciate the different ways in which people communicate, connect and express themselves.

BSL reflects our Academy vision, *Love Learning Together*, in a particularly meaningful way. Children from KCA and Frank Barnes share a community, and developing a common means of communication helps children interact, learn and participate alongside one another. Through BSL, children also develop our KCA values of Respect and Kindness while having the courage to communicate in a language that may initially be unfamiliar to them.

Our Intent

Our BSL curriculum is ambitious, inclusive and carefully sequenced from Nursery to Year 3. It identifies the essential vocabulary, language structures, communication skills and cultural knowledge we want children to develop, enabling them to become increasingly confident in understanding and using British Sign Language.

Children progressively develop a growing vocabulary of signs and learn to combine these to communicate in familiar and meaningful situations. New learning builds upon previously taught language, with regular opportunities to revisit, practise and apply signs so that children develop increasing fluency and confidence.

Children learn that BSL is a language in its own right, with its own grammar and structures, rather than a signed version of spoken English. As their knowledge develops, children begin to recognise how meaning is communicated through handshape, movement, location, orientation and non-manual features such as facial expression and body movement.

Communication is at the heart of our approach. Children have regular opportunities to watch, understand and respond to BSL as well as produce signs themselves. They learn to communicate with increasing confidence and to use what they know in meaningful interactions rather than simply learning individual signs in isolation.

Alongside developing their language, children learn about Deaf culture, community and identity. They develop an age-appropriate understanding of the importance of BSL to the Deaf community and recognise that being Deaf is not simply defined by an inability to hear, but can also involve a rich linguistic and cultural identity.

Our co-location with Frank Barnes gives this learning an authentic purpose. BSL is not something children encounter only within a lesson: it is a language used by children and adults within the community they share every day.

Every Child

We have high expectations for every child. Children with SEND, children who are disadvantaged and children who are developing English as an additional language have access to the same ambitious BSL curriculum.

BSL is inherently visual and physical, providing children with another way to understand and express meaning. Teaching uses clear modelling, repetition, visual cues, interaction and frequent opportunities for practice so that children develop confidence over time.

Teachers recognise that children will develop their BSL at different rates and adapt teaching and opportunities for practice so that barriers to participation are reduced without lowering expectations.

Our linguistically diverse community means that many KCA children already understand that people can communicate using more than one language. Learning BSL broadens this understanding further, helping children recognise and value the many different ways in which people communicate.

BSL Beyond the Curriculum

Our relationship with Frank Barnes School for Deaf Children makes BSL a distinctive part of life at KCA. Sharing our site creates opportunities for children to encounter BSL naturally and understand why the language they are learning matters.

Opportunities for children from both schools to learn, perform and participate alongside one another allow KCA pupils to apply their BSL in authentic situations and develop confidence communicating beyond the classroom.

Our shared experiences also provide opportunities for children to encounter Deaf adults and children, helping them understand that there is no single Deaf experience and ensuring that their understanding of Deaf culture is informed by the people for whom BSL is part of everyday life.

BSL contributes to the wider culture of communication at KCA. Alongside our emphasis on spoken language, listening and performance, it helps children understand that effective

communication involves attending carefully to another person, adapting how we communicate and ensuring that everyone has opportunities to participate.

By the end of Year 3, our aim is not simply that children can recall a collection of signs. We want them to draw upon a growing BSL vocabulary to understand and communicate meaning, recognise some of the linguistic features that make BSL a language and have developed an informed appreciation of Deaf culture and identity.

Above all, we want children to leave their BSL learning as confident, respectful and inclusive communicators who recognise BSL as an important language within their own school community and within the wider world.